SETTING · D&D 2024

Hallownest

A fallen kingdom beneath a quiet town. The roads are empty, the dead still wander them, and an orange light glows behind too many eyes.

V0.1 PLAYTEST SETTING SKETCH INSPIRED BY HOLLOW KNIGHT

What It Is

Hallownest was once a great kingdom on the edge of the Underdark, raised by the Pale King, a being of light who gave the bugs of the deep their minds and their order. Travelers reach it from the surface through the town of Dirtmouth, either down the old well or by the King's Pass, a long, winding tunnel the kingdom's founders once walked.

Hallownest fell to the Infection: a plague spread through dreams by the Radiance, an old moth god the kingdom chose to forget. To contain her, the Pale King sealed the Radiance inside a hollow vessel and locked it in the Black Egg Temple beneath Dirtmouth. The seal held for an age. Now it's failing, and the kingdom below is a ruin of husks, ghosts, and the few stubborn souls who never left.

The Infection

Track Infection for each character who travels below Dirtmouth. At the end of each Long Rest taken anywhere other than a bench, a character makes a DC 13 Wisdom saving throw, gaining 1 Infection on a failure. A character also gains 1 Infection when a creature of the Infection deals a Critical Hit to them.

INFECTION	EFFECT
1	**Orange Dreams.** Dreams turn warm, bright, and welcoming. No mechanical effect, but the Radiance knows the character's name.
2	**Glowing Eyes.** The character has Disadvantage on Wisdom saving throws against being Charmed, and infected creatures treat them as kin until they attack.
3	**The Light Calls.** Once per day, the DM can have the character spend their Reaction moving up to their Speed toward the nearest source of the Infection.
4	**Husk.** The character has the Charmed condition toward the Radiance and becomes an NPC until cured.

Curing Infection takes a lifeblood cocoon, a *greater restoration*, or a visit to the Blue Lake. Each removes 1 Infection.

Benches

Benches are scattered throughout Hallownest: old resting places, some still warm. A Long Rest at a bench is safe from the Infection save, and resting at one marks it as a place the party can find again.

Places of Note

- **Dirtmouth.** The near-empty town on the surface, kept by a single elder and a handful of travelers. It sits on the well that leads down.
- **The Forgotten Crossroads.** The kingdom's old main roads, the first to fall and the most thoroughly infected.
- **Greenpath.** A lush, overgrown garden where moss knights keep the old ways of Unn.

- **The City of Tears.** The kingdom's capital, under eternal rain from the lake above. Its towers hold the Soul Sanctum and the Watcher's Spire.
- **Deepnest.** A dark, twisting labyrinth of tunnels and webs, home to spiders and to things worse than spiders.
- **Kingdom's Edge.** Ash-pale cliffs at the edge of the world, where the Hive hums and the Colosseum of Fools still holds its trials.
- **The Queen's Gardens.** Overgrown royal gardens patrolled by mantis warriors and haunted by the absent White Lady.
- **The Abyss.** The black pit beneath everything, where the Pale King made his vessels and the Void still stirs.
- **The Black Egg Temple.** The sealed prison of the Hollow Knight, beneath Dirtmouth. Every crack in its shell shows on the skin of the world above.

Who You Meet

- **Elderbug,** Dirtmouth's last resident, cheerful, lonely, and full of opinions about everyone who's left.
- **Cornifer,** a humming cartographer who leaves trails of paper behind him and sells maps of everywhere he's been.
- **Quirrel,** a soft-spoken wanderer drawn back to Hallownest by memories he can't place.
- **The Seer,** an old moth in the Resting Grounds who collects essence from dreams and knows more about the Radiance than she says.
- **Hornet,** a sharp-tongued protector of the kingdom who tests anyone she suspects could become its next threat.

Roads of the Fallen Kingdom

Roll once per day the party travels below.

D6	EVENT
1	**Wandering Husks.** A shuffling crowd of infected bugs walks old commute routes. They ignore the party unless disturbed.

D6	EVENT
2	**Cornifer's Trail.** Scraps of map paper lead to a cheerful cartographer and a map of the current area, for a price.
3	**A Shade.** A dark shadow of some lost wanderer drifts nearby. Defeat it, and its coin purse is the party's.
4	**Orange Bloom.** A pocket of Infection pulses in the walls. Each creature passing through makes a DC 13 Constitution saving throw or gains 1 Infection.
5	**Grubs.** A trapped grub calls for help from a jar. Freeing it earns the gratitude of the Grubfather, and a small reward.
6	**A Warm Bench.** Someone kept this one tidy. The next Long Rest here grants 1 Hit Die back.

Adventure Hooks

1. The dreams of Dirtmouth's few residents have started to glow orange. Something beneath the town has cracked, and the Elderbug has no one else to ask.
2. Cornifer has gone missing in Deepnest, and his wife Iselda will pay well for his safe return and his maps.
3. The Seer believes the Radiance can be slain in the dream world, if someone gathers enough essence to reach her.

Tie-ins

Warrior of the Void (the Abyss and Void Heart), Soul Sanctum (City of Tears), Circle of Unn (Greenpath), Path of the Hive (Kingdom's Edge), Mantis Lord (Mantis Village), Oath of the Pale Throne (the White Palace and the Five Great Knights), Nailmaster (the three masters' huts), Nightmare Troupe (the lantern in Dirtmouth), The Radiance (the Infection itself), and Void Sorcery.

Take a long rest, we'll wake you for the loot.

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